were instrumental in resolving disputes, though the exact details remain confidential.[31]

At the same time, NATO employed sidelining tactics to pressure Erdoğan. The United States canceled plans for Erdoğan to visit Washington and imposed sanctions on Turkey, including the suspension of F-35 fighter jet sales following Turkey's purchase of Russian S-400 missile system.[32] These moves isolated Erdoğan diplomatically and signaled NATO's frustration with his obstructionist stance.[33]

Publicly, NATO leaders, including Stoltenberg, used social media strategically to portray productive engagements with Erdoğan, emphasizing progress in the negotiations and framing Turkey's eventual cooperation as a mutual success. Tweets from Stoltenberg often showcased images of him with Erdoğan, accompanied by messages of shared achievements, which may have been an effort to bolster NATO's image among the Turkish public.[34]

Ultimately, Turkey approved NATO's expansion in 2024, marking a significant victory for the alliance. Despite ongoing disputes, Turkey remains a key player within NATO, contributing to counterterrorism efforts and regional stability. NATO continues to engage with Turkey, recognizing its strategic importance while managing the challenges posed by Erdoğan's populist rhetoric and policy demands (Giannotta 2020).

However, these prolonged disputes have allowed Erdoğan to bolster his populist image domestically. Concessions from NATO enabled him to claim victories in negotiations, reinforcing his narrative of standing up to elite powers and defending Turkish sovereignty. The canceled F-35 sale, in particular, became fodder for Erdoğan's rhetoric about NATO's perceived inequities, fueling anti-elite sentiment among his supporters.[35] While NATO's strategies have maintained Turkey's participation and secured key objectives, they may have also inadvertently amplified Erdoğan's populist agenda, highlighting the delicate balance the alliance must strike in dealing with populist leaders within its ranks.

8.4 NATO and Trump

Similar to Erdoğan, US president Donald Trump's first term featured frequent clashes with NATO, particularly over funding. With the United